

Negotiation Skills



Unlearning Negotiation Missteps

Common mistakes freelancers make when negotiating and how to avoid them.

Thinking Negotiation = Price Only

Saying "Yes" Too Quickly

Being Afraid to Ask for More



Overpromising Just to Win the Project

Being Too Rigid

Not Getting Things in Writing

Taking Rejection Personally

What is Negotiation?

A negotiation is a communication process involving two or more parties aiming to reach an agreement or trying to present the best idea to conclude benefiting all.

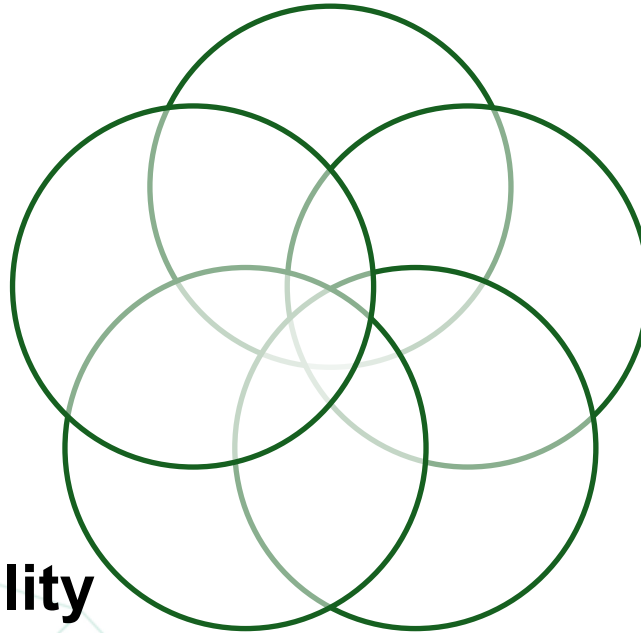
Each party endeavors to achieve a satisfactory agreement through influence, persuasion, or bargaining.

It involves **offering**, **compromising**, and **finding a solution** that works for everyone.

Why Negotiation is Essential for Freelancers

Helps avoid scope creep

Builds professional credibility



Ensures fair compensation

Protects your rights as an independent worker

Freelance vs Traditional Job Negotiation

Aspect	Traditional Jobs	Freelancing
Representation	HR personnel or manager	You represent yourself
Client/Employer Communication	Usually indirect	Direct with the client
Flexibility of Terms	Fixed in a formal contract	Flexible (you can accept, reject, or modify)
Pricing	Predefined by the company	You set the price based on value and project
Task Assignment	Fixed and assigned by management	Negotiable per client and project
Negotiation on Revisions	Rare – based on company policy	Common – requires a clear agreement
Client Choice	None – you're bound to the company	Full – you choose whom you work with

Effective Freelance Negotiation Strategies



Three-tier pricing strategy

Offer 3 different service packages to give clients options and increase earnings.

Using your portfolio to support your rate

Show quality work samples to justify your pricing.

Knowing when to say "no" without losing the client

Set healthy boundaries while maintaining professionalism.

Handling pushy or indecisive clients

Stay calm and guide the client through clear questions and options.

Key Goals of a Good Negotiation

Quality: A fair, smart deal that works for both

Cost: Efficient use of your time and resources

Harmony: Keeping good long-term relationships

Lewicki and Hiam's Negotiation Matrix Goals

In any negotiation two important **goals** should be always considered.
you choose your negotiation strategy based upon two factors

The importance of the outcome:

how important substantive results are, such as money, time, accomplishment, etc.

The importance of the relationship:

how important relational outcomes are, such as building or maintaining your relationship with the counterparty

Lewicki and Hiam's Negotiation Matrix is a tool that helps you choose the best negotiation strategy.



The matrix consists of **five negotiation strategies**:

1. Competing
2. Accommodating
3. Avoiding
4. Compromising
5. Collaborating

Competing (Win-Lose)

his strategy focuses on **achieving the best possible outcome for yourself**, even if it means the other party loses. It is often used when the outcome is critical, and maintaining the relationship is not a priority.

Accommodating (Lose-Win)

Here, you **prioritize the relationship** over the outcome, often giving in to the other party's demands. While this helps maintain goodwill, it comes at the cost of not achieving the best possible result for yourself.

Avoiding (Lose-Lose)

In this case, neither party **achieves a favorable outcome** because the issue is ignored or postponed indefinitely. It is typically used when the negotiation is not worth the effort or when both sides prefer to avoid conflict.

Compromising (Partial Win-Win)

This approach seeks a **middle ground** where both parties **make concessions**. While neither side gets everything they want, both gain something, making it a fair but not optimal solution.

Collaborating (Win-Win)

The ideal strategy when **both the outcome and the relationship are important**. It involves working together to find a solution that satisfies both parties' interests, ensuring mutual success.



How to be a Good Negotiator

Negotiation Coach Prompt

Act as an expert Freelance Negotiation Coach.

I will provide:

- My freelance service: [your service]
- My experience level: [Beginner / Intermediate / Advanced]
- The client's message: [paste the client's reply]

Based on professional freelance negotiation principles, generate:

1. The best professional reply to the client.
2. Explain why this is the best response.
3. Identify the negotiation strategy used (Collaborating, Compromising, Competing, Accommodating, or Avoiding).
4. If appropriate, suggest a better offer (pricing, scope, deadline, revisions, or package).
5. If the client asks for a discount, recommend how to respond without undervaluing my work.
6. If the client has a low budget, suggest a win-win alternative instead of simply accepting or rejecting.
7. If the client requests urgent delivery, explain whether an extra fee should be charged and how to communicate it professionally.
8. Point out any negotiation mistakes I should avoid.
9. Rewrite the response in a confident, friendly, and client-focused tone.

Follow these negotiation principles:

- Never accept the first offer immediately.
- Negotiate value, not just price.
- Protect the project scope and revision limits.
- Use my portfolio and expertise to justify pricing.
- Offer alternatives instead of saying "No."
- Keep all agreements clear and professional.
- Aim for a win-win outcome whenever possible.

Tips to Be a Good Negotiator (Especially for Freelancers)







Do's and Don'ts in Negotiation

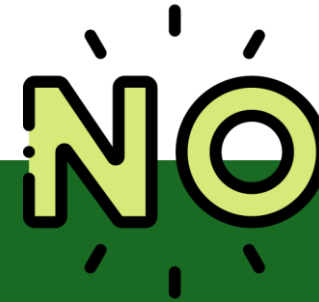
Dos	Don'ts
Prepare thoroughly Research the client and know your value.	Accept or reject too quickly Don't rush your decision but take time to evaluate.
Listen actively Understand the client's needs and concerns.	Focus only on price Negotiation is also about deadlines, revisions, and terms.
Set clear goals Know what you want and what you can compromise on.	Be too rigid Being inflexible can break the deal.
Be flexible Look for win-win solutions and stay open-minded.	Ignore body language Non-verbal cues are part of communication.
Communicate clearly and respectfully Use polite, professional language.	Forget to document agreements Always get the final terms in writing.
Control your emotions Stay calm and professional even under pressure.	Take things personally Rejection is part of the process, not a failure.

Free Services: When and Why??



When to Offer Free Services

- Building Your Portfolio
- Attracting Clients
- Demonstrating Value

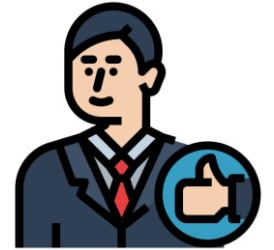


When Not to Offer Free Services

- Devaluing Your Work
- Unsustainable Practice
- Lack of Commitment

Different types of difficult Clients Behaviors

Client Type	Traits	Freelancer Tips (How to Deal)
Perfectionist Client	Obsesses over every detail, struggles to prioritize, aims for unrealistic perfection which may delay progress.	▪ Avoid assigning them projects with tight deadlines or flexible scopes. ▪ Gently highlight the behavior and its downsides. ▪ Help them focus on priorities and key outcomes. ▪ Be sensitive when giving feedback & avoid direct criticism.
Defensive Client	Takes feedback personally, reacts negatively to suggestions or constructive criticism, which can slow collaboration.	▪ Start conversations with positives. ▪ Focus on the issue, not the person - depersonalize it. ▪ Avoid blame-oriented language. ▪ Show empathy and understanding.



Client Type	Traits	Freelancer Tips (How to Deal)
Aggressive Client	Attacks ideas or people, blames others, displays anger, hostility, or dominance in communication.	- Stay calm and don't react emotionally. - Address the group (if in a call), not just the individual. - Remain neutral and composed. - Try to find common ground.
Complaining Client	Constantly finds faults, blames others, dismisses suggestions but offers no solutions or alternatives.	- Ask clarifying questions to dig into real issues. - Don't get defensive or retaliate. - Shift the focus to problem-solving. - Set clear timelines and shared decision points.
Arrogant Client	Overconfident, controlling, believes they always know best, often dismissive of others' input.	- Show that trusting others can still lead to great results. - Know your stuff — be confident and factual. - Acknowledge parts of their ideas. - Use "we" language. - Set clear boundaries for collaboration.



Freelancing Negotiation Scenarios



<https://www.menti.com/alzb39y28uqa>

Case studies

1.Low Budget

Client say I only have \$20, but I need a full project

Your response:

💬 *"For that budget, I can offer a simpler version. Would you like to see what that includes?"*

..Urgent Delivery2

Client says"Can you deliver everything by tomorrow

Your response:

💬 *"I can deliver faster with an extra fee, to ensure quality. Would that work for you?"*

3. Unclear Brief

Client saysI just want something that looks nice

Your response:

💬 *"Can you clarify your main goals and provide examples of what you like? That helps me meet your expectations."*

Thank You !

